the success of our policies in the United States had made it easier for her to convince Britons the policies had merit. As everyone now knows, her policies touched off a boom that brought great prosperity to the British people. In many ways she accomplished more than we did in returning government-run enterprises to where they belonged—the private sector—and created a model that has since been copied by other countries. I wish we could have done as well on this as she did. Maybe the difference between what a prime minister can accomplish and what a president can do has to do with the fact that a prime minister automatically has a majority in Parliament, and a president can't say the same thing about our Congress. For all of my eight years in office, the opposing party had a majority in our House of Representatives.

Before going to my first economic summit, I'd wondered what it would be like to have the heads of seven nations in the same room: What tensions of ego and status would be at work? As I will explain shortly, we did have occasional conflicts. But, as our first meeting got started, I was surprised to hear the others addressing each other by their first names. When I got my first chance to speak, I said, "My name's Ron . . ."

Although I never asked her about it, I think the idea of addressing the other summit leaders by their first names was Margaret Thatcher's. It did wonders to make the meetings cordial and productive. I was always Ron to the others and I addressed them by their first names.

Once I was no longer the freshman of the group, I went out of my way to tell newcomers about the policy. When the new Japanese prime minister, Yasuhiro Nakasone, came to his first summit, for example, I asked him, "What does your wife call you at home?"

He said, "Yasu."